

Russians Breach Mariupol; Barracks Strike Kills Dozens



A survivor was pulled from the rubble Saturday in Mykolaiv, Ukraine, a day after a missile strike killed at least 40 marines. Page 16.

U.S. Isn’t Ready
If Covid Surges,
Scientists Warn

By BENJAMIN MUELLER

Scarcely two months after the Omicron variant drove coronavirus case numbers to frightening heights in the United States, scientists and health officials are bracing for another swell in the pandemic and, with it, the first major test of the country’s strategy of living with the virus while limiting its impact.

At local, state and federal levels, the nation has been relaxing restrictions and trying to restore a semblance of normalcy. Encouraging Americans to return to prepandemic routines, officials are lifting mask and vaccine mandates and showing no inclination of closing down offices, restaurants or theaters.

But scientists are warning that the United States isn’t doing enough to prevent a new surge from endangering vulnerable Americans and potentially upending life again.

New pills can treat infections, but federal efforts to buy more of them are in limbo. An aid package in Congress is stalled, even as agencies run out of money for tests and therapeutics. Though less than one-third of the population has the booster shots needed for high levels of protection, the daily vaccination rate has fallen to a low.

While some Americans may never be persuaded to roll up their sleeves, experts said that health officials could be doing a lot more, for example, to get booster shots to the doorsteps of older people who have proved willing to take the initial doses.

“You use the quiet periods to do the hard work,” said Jennifer Nuzzo, an epidemiologist at Johns Hopkins Bloomberg School of Public Health. “You don’t use the quiet to forget.”

The clearest warnings that the brief period of quiet may soon be over have come, as they often have in the past two years, from Western Europe. In a number of countries, including Britain, France and Germany, case num-

Continued on Page 22



Less than a third of Americans have gotten booster shots, like these offered in Washington.

Fight for Kyiv Looms as a Long, Fierce Conflict

By ANDREW E. KRAMER

KYIV, Ukraine — The city of Kyiv covers 325 square miles and is divided by a broad river. It has about 500,000 structures — factories, ornate churches and high-rise apartments — many on narrow, winding streets. Roughly two million people remain after extensive evacuations of women and children.

To the northwest and to the east, tens of thousands of Russian troops are pressing toward the city, Ukraine’s capital, backed by columns of tanks, armored vehicles and artillery. Inside Kyiv, Ukrainian soldiers and civilian volunteers are fortifying the downtown with barriers, anti-tank mines and artillery.

Kyiv remains the biggest prize

May Be Biggest Urban
Battle in 80 Years

of all for the Russian military; it is the seat of government and ingrained in both Russian and Ukrainian identity. But capturing it, military analysts say, would require a furious and bloody conflict that could be the world’s biggest urban battle in 80 years.

“What we are looking at in Kyiv would dwarf anything we’ve seen since World War II,” said David Kilcullen, a retired lieutenant colonel in the Australian Army who has extensively studied urban combat. “If they really, really want to level Kyiv, they can,” he said of the Russian leadership.

“But the level of political and economic damage would be tremendous.”

For comparison, one of the largest urban battles this century was the nine-month siege of Mosul, Iraq, in 2016 and 2017 to oust its Islamic State occupiers. Mosul covers 70 square miles and had a wartime population of about 750,000 people — a fraction of the numbers for Kyiv, where the metropolitan area’s prewar population was 3.6 million.

Negotiations over a cease-fire are continuing, and a long, heated battle over Kyiv is not inevitable. Despite superior numbers and firepower, Russia has not achieved a breakthrough. A Western official, in a briefing with reporters this past week, said the

Continued on Page 15

U.S. Goal: Stave Off,
Don’t Set Off, Putin

This article is by Mark Mazzetti, Helene Cooper, Julian E. Barnes and David E. Sanger.

WASHINGTON — In the first weeks of the first major European land war of the 21st century, the United States has sent tank-killing weapons to Ukrainian forces, but not fighter jets. It is equipping embattled Ukrainian troops with lightweight “kamikaze” attack drones, but not, at least in an obvious way, conducting an aggressive cyberwar to degrade Russia’s technological advantage.

The White House will commit no American or NATO planes to the skies above Ukraine, a move American officials fear could risk turning a regional war into a global conflagration, but it is providing Ukraine with missiles that could accomplish the same task of destroying Russian aircraft.

Such is the tenuous balance the Biden administration has tried to maintain as it seeks to help Ukraine lock Russia in a quagmire without inciting a broader conflict with a nuclear-armed adversary or cutting off potential paths to de-escalation.

Navigating this path has led to a tangle of decisions, and sometimes tortured distinctions, when it comes to what kinds of assistance Washington should provide, even as the situation on the ground evolves, pictures of dead civilians circulate around the globe and President Volodymyr Zelensky of Ukraine pleads with Congress and President Biden to do more to help.

The balancing act informs every aspect of American policy about the war, including the scope of the punishing sanctions imposed on the Russian economy, the granularity of the battlefield intelligence provided to Ukrainian troops, the killing power of the weapons systems coming over the border and whether, as Mr. Biden did this past week, to label

Continued on Page 10

Zelensky Seeks Talks
but Vows to Fight

This article is by Michael Levenson, Marc Santora and Valerie Hopkins.

Russian forces made significant gains in Ukraine on Saturday, advancing into the besieged port of Mariupol, destroying an underground weapons depot in the west and leaving a marine barracks in ruins following one of the deadliest rocket strikes on Ukraine’s military in the nearly month-old war.

As the fighting raged, Ukraine faced a worsening humanitarian crisis, and military losses mounted on both sides. A senior Ukrainian military official said on Saturday that the strike on the barracks, which happened Friday in the southern city of Mykolaiv, had killed more than 40 soldiers.

Separately, Russia’s Defense Ministry claimed on Saturday that it had used a hypersonic missile for the first time to destroy an underground ammunition depot in the western region of Ivano-Frankivsk. Ukraine’s military spokesman confirmed the hit on Saturday, but said the missile type was “yet to be determined.”

If confirmed, the Russian military’s use of a new generation of its missiles, called Kinzhal or Dagger, would mark an escalation in the conflict. Hypersonic missiles are capable of flying at five times the speed of sound, according to military analysts.

President Volodymyr Zelensky of Ukraine on Saturday appealed directly to Russians to support a diplomatic resolution to the war, and added a stark warning.

“I want everyone to hear me now, especially in Moscow,” Mr. Zelensky said in a video address hours after President Vladimir V. Putin of Russia had spoken to tens of thousands of Russians in a rally at Moscow’s largest stadium. “It’s time to meet, time to talk. It is time to restore territorial integrity and justice for Ukraine. Otherwise,

Continued on Page 16

SOVIET SCARS The war is posing a strategic dilemma for countries like Georgia, which endured its own Russian invasion in 2008. PAGE 14

FAR APART A top official in Turkey, which has been acting as a mediator, said Putin wasn’t ready for direct talks with Zelensky. PAGE 14

‘My Heart Burst’: The Voices of Women Escaping War

Sabrina Tavernise interviewed four Ukrainian women fleeing the front lines of the war. This is the account of Maria Nuzhna, 36, an interior designer who escaped the village of Andriyivka, west of Kyiv, which Russia occupied in early March. More on Page 12.

I kept a diary. When I realized that day was like a day but not exactly like a day, I started writing down what was going on because I woke up, I didn’t know what day of the week it was. I didn’t know what date it was because it seemed like it was going on for a long time even though it was a few days.

Our house and garden is on 25 acres. We plant vegetables there. If you go out of the house, you can see the old farm next to us. The Russians put a Grad rocket launcher in this farm. We counted how many volleys. From three to seven and sometimes up to 30. It makes very scary noises — I can’t express to you how scary. It makes this sound: shoooh, shoooh, shoooh. These rockets they fly with such force, and at night they make these red streaks. It sounds like a murderous force.

Missiles were also hitting. Tanks were passing by. The roof was constantly shaking. The dishes in the closet clattering. And I feel it with my feet.

The first time the Russian soldiers came to us, they said they wanted to check the men’s documents and see how many of us were in the house. They said we had to tie a white rag on the gate to show that people lived in this house. My husband’s mother did not let them in. She said, “No, we have children in the house.”



Maria Nuzhna with her daughters, Sofia, 12, and Solomiia, 7. The family fled their home on March 10 after days of shelling.

Suddenly, I heard bangs. There are four people out on the street from our family. And four shots were fired. Bang bang bang bang. It was like my heart burst. The children started screaming: “Where’s Dad?” I ran outside, then saw that both my husband and brother and husband’s parents were still talking, that they were still alive.

We were lucky because my husband’s mother, she found a connection. The soldiers were from Dagestan and Buryatiya. They were not Russian. Russians are mean. But these were national minorities.

My mother-in-law, she said, “We’ve also been to Dagestan.” She was very calm with him.

He said, “We’re here to protect

you.” She said to him, “From whom?” He said they were looking for foreigners in the village.

They really believed that there is no army in Ukraine and that foreigners are fighting for us. They hear from the propaganda that Russia is at war with NATO and with the West here. They believe that they should remove all weapons because Ukraine is under the control of America and NATO.

We left on March 10.

And for the first time since it began, I went out of the gate. My husband had the children in his car. I was carrying the guinea pigs. I was driving alone and crying. Tanks were in people’s yards. Equipment scattered. One car was just a pile of metal. A bike was broken in two pieces. Gates had fallen off houses.

We saw two soldiers in uniform lay facedown on one part of the road. I was worried they were ours. But then I saw they had dark green uniforms, and most likely they were Russians. It’s so inhuman. People are like meat.

When we finally got out and we were in a city in Ivano-Frankivsk region, we went to buy some clothes and a teapot. And I saw people in a shopping center buying flowers, and I overheard snippets of conversation, someone saying someone had a birthday. And as I was standing in the middle of all this, I had the feeling that I was still there under occupation. And that this was a parallel reality, this was a dream. It was a very strange feeling.

Now I’m talking to you and crying, but I haven’t cried for two days. This is my personal achievement.

Stalking Trucks
For a Bounty
In New York

By MICHAEL WILSON and SARAH BLESENER

A white-paneled midsize motoring and idling in Midtown on a recent morning, its driver wrapped up in his phone and oblivious to what was happening outside.

There in the street, Paul Slapikas was stalking his prey. Wire-thin and 81 years old, Mr. Slapikas stood in front of the truck like a lost tourist, a camera dangling around his neck and a map sticking out of his jacket pocket. He appeared to be deep in conversation on an old flip-phone — big hand gestures, a peek at a watch, a crane of the neck like he’s looking for a friend.

After exactly three minutes and 10 seconds, Mr. Slapikas — a lifelong New Yorker who lives a few miles away in Queens — snapped the phone shut, tapped the screen of his watch and walked away. If everything goes as it should, he just earned \$87.50, and maybe more, for those few minutes of time, and the company that owns the truck will receive a fine of at least \$350 that it never saw coming. But for now, Mr. Slapikas is off down the block, a bounty hunter jauntily seeking his next target.

“Easy pickings,” said the former marine and retired computer specialist from Woodside.

This is a scene from the city’s benign-sounding but often raucous Citizens Air Complaint Program, a public health campaign that invites — and pays — people to report trucks that are parked and idling for more than three minutes, or one minute if outside a school. Those who report collect 25 percent of any fine against a truck by submitting a video just

Continued on Page 23